

Navigating subjectivity in causal context

A non-deterministic approach for information behaviour research

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The generalization impasse in LIS

- Library and Information Science has built rich theoretical frameworks, but empirical studies remain bound by methods oriented toward population-wide generalization.
- A typical information behaviour research project in context requires its own specific design and methodological development.
- The full potential of in-context research is not in chasing sweeping averages, but in supporting decision-making based on local evidence.
- We need dedicated designs that evaluate context-specific configurations rather than default generalization.

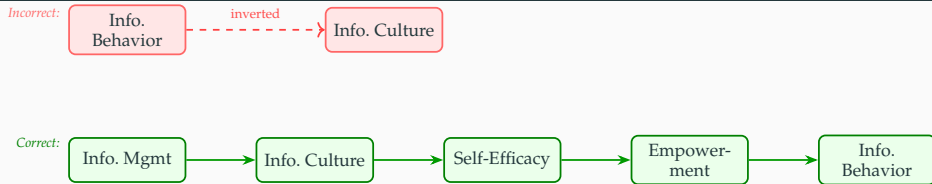
Subjective structures & effects of causes

- Subjectivity is the very area where the effect of causes is located.
- FSSM captures how the effects of a cause, whether adjacent (proximal interaction) or coercive (structural policies, culture, and norms), reside within the subjective structure of human perception rather than acting as deterministic drivers.
- Environmental and institutional factors do not directly force behaviour; their impact is filtered through how individuals subjectively perceive and experience affordances and constraints.

Beyond the “average” human

- Regression models produce parameter estimates: central tendencies across a population that abstract away the individual variation information behaviour research most needs to understand.
- FSSM shifts focus to subjectivity mapping, assessing:
 - Sufficiency: which context conditions typically enable the outcome.
 - Typicality: regularities that hold for nearly all cases in a group.
 - Necessity: non-compensatory bottlenecks (critical gatekeepers).
 - Probability: individual likelihood given context conditions.
- We examine how far or close each person is from an empirically grounded threshold rather than computing aggregate summaries.

Arrow-reversal & context-first skeleton



- A common regression puts information behaviour on the left: use predicts culture. Associatively this holds, people adapt to environments. Causally, culture shapes what people can do.
- Reversing the arrows conflates adaptation with causation; confounders like discipline sustain spurious paths in either direction.
- FSSM enforces the skeleton: Management and Culture upstream; Self-Efficacy and Empowerment intermediate; Information Behaviour downstream.

The four causal claims of FSSM

1. Typical Sufficiency (α): “If $X \geq T_X$, then $Y \geq T_Y$ for most cases.” Policies usually suffice to produce the behaviour; rare exceptions are allowed.
2. Typical Necessity (ϵ): “If Y is high, X is rarely below its bottleneck.”
Non-compensatory constraint: a gatekeeper whose absence blocks success.
3. Probabilistic Sufficiency (Δ / Uplift): Does raising X above the threshold increase the probability of high Y ? Computed on an IPW-balanced pseudo-population.
4. Probabilistic Necessity (β): “When X is below its bottleneck, high Y is unlikely.” Converts the constraint into a counterfactual risk statement.

Four causal claims: mathematical form

$$\alpha = \frac{\sum_i w_i \cdot \mathbf{1}(x_i \geq T_X) \cdot \mathbf{1}(y_i \geq T_Y)}{\sum_i w_i \cdot \mathbf{1}(x_i \geq T_X)}$$

$$\varepsilon = \frac{\sum_i w_i \cdot \mathbf{1}(y_i \geq T_Y) \cdot \mathbf{1}(x_i < T_X)}{\sum_i w_i \cdot \mathbf{1}(y_i \geq T_Y)}$$

$$\Delta = \Pr^*(Y \geq T_Y \mid X \geq T_X) - \Pr^*(Y \geq T_Y \mid X < T_X)$$

$$\beta = \Pr^*(Y \geq T_Y \mid X < T_X)$$

T_X and T_Y anchor all four claims. Decision thresholds for α , ε , β are not fixed; they depend on decision context and may be benchmarked analogously to classical effect-size conventions (e.g., Cohen's d or Cramér's V).

Dual logic: latent vs. composite route

- Route A (Latent Variable Route, PLS-SEM + NCA): Extends latent structural models. Achieves population generalization via structural paths while exploring necessity bottlenecks case by case. A sound ground for causal generalization with reversal to case-wise interpretation.
- Route B (Raw Composite Route, NCA + Case Weighting): Bypasses latent modelling by using raw composites. Enables a case-level “finding people” approach: NCA identifies the threshold T_X for a specific desired T_Y , and every respondent is located on the resulting membership scale.
- Route B allows researchers to study teams, even small ones, to diagnose their specific information needs and behaviours based on local evidence, without demanding full latent measurement.

Double subjectivity: entropy weighting & IPW

FSSM addresses subjectivity at two levels:

1. Measurement subjectivity: respondents read items through disciplinary lenses.
Entropy weighting up-weights discriminating indicators, down-weights noise:

$$w_j^{\text{EW}} \propto H(j) = - \sum_k p_{jk} \log p_{jk}$$

2. Confounding: group differences may reflect discipline or seniority, not the construct.
IPW re-balances the sample:

$$w_i^{\text{IPW}} = \frac{D_i}{\hat{e}(c_i)} + \frac{1 - D_i}{1 - \hat{e}(c_i)}, \quad \hat{e}(c_i) = \Pr(D_i = 1 \mid c_i)$$

- Together, these two layers move FSSM from association toward principled intervention contrasts under explicitly stated identification assumptions.

Fuzzy concept & subjectivity mapping

- Continuous latent and composite scores are mapped onto a fuzzy membership interval $[0, 1]$ relative to empirical thresholds and bottlenecks.
- $\mu_S(x)$: degree to which an individual case meets the necessary context bottleneck, showing how close a case is to crossing the enabling threshold.
- $\mu_Y(y)$: degree of outcome achievement relative to the desired target T_Y .
- Graded membership honours individual autonomy: it shows who clears the threshold, who falls short, and who represents a critical exception, without binary cutoffs.

Fuzzy membership: mathematical form

Membership in the necessary bottleneck for condition X:

$$\mu_S(x_i) = \begin{cases} 0 & x_i = 0 \\ \frac{x_i}{T_X} & 0 < x_i < T_X \\ 1 & x_i \geq T_X \end{cases} \quad \mu_Y(y_i) = \min\left(1, \frac{y_i}{T_Y}\right)$$

The pair $(\mu_S(x_i), \mu_Y(y_i))$ locates every respondent on a self-treatment scale. The institutional environment is an ongoing exogenous context continuously shaping each individual's endogenous subjective structure. Threshold-seeking replaces point-treatment logic: not “did an intervention occur?” but “how far is this person from the enabling threshold?” In FSSM, treatment is replaced with threshold-seeking as an individual's ongoing reaction to persistent environmental conditions.

Thank you

Thank you for your attention

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FSSM Project & Updates on OSF:

`osf.io/b8maq/`